Early humans and megafauna

In the last 60,000 years, which includes the end of the last ice age, about 51 genera of large mammals became extinct in North America. Most were herbivores, including ground sloths, mastodons, and large armadillos, but many were carnivores, such as American lions and cheetahs, scimitar cats, and short-faced bears.

Many of the extinctions occurred between 11,500 and 10,000 years ago, shortly after the arrival and spread of the Clovis people, who were hunters. One of the most convincing theories about these developments is the “second-order predation hypothesis,” which suggests that the humans triggered a trophic cascade. The people killed the large carnivores, which competed with them for prey. As a result, predator numbers were reduced and prey populations rose disproportionately, resulting in overgrazing. The vegetation could no longer support the herbivores, with the result that many herbivores starved.